

ANI

FEM FLAMBEAU ASHA workers shine the torch on their plight in Thiruvananthapuram; the strike was called off after 266 days

Not that Kerala had much. In 2023, the NITI Aayog pegged it at 0.55 per cent of the state's 33.34 million population. Kerala's own survey yielded about 80,000 short of that: a total of 103,099 people from 64,006 families, spread over 1,032 local self-government (LSG) bodies.

FOR THE 'LAST ONES'

The key criteria, says LSG minister M.B. Rajesh, were "stress factors such as lack of food, healthcare requirements, income basis and lack of housing". Of those 64,006 families, he says, the single members of around 4,421 had died and 261 nomadic families could not be traced. Special "micro-plans" were then "designed for each family", Rajesh told INDIA TODAY. LSG special secretary T.V. Anupama elaborates that this included short- to long-term components on provision of food, shelter, healthcare, insurance, job cards and children's scholarships.

Congress leader and LoP V.D. Satheeshan calls the claim a "fraud and publicity stunt", enacted in time for local body polls due in November-December. "Who eliminated 590,174 Antyodaya Anna Yojana card holders, the poorest of the poor? Why were only 60,006 families chosen?" he asks. Tribal activists, too, are sceptical. "Our lives are all the same. We live in poverty," K. Ammini of the Adivasi Women's Organisation told INDIA TODAY. "The state may have spent large sums to claim this unique title. But thousands of tribal children are dropping out of school, hundreds of our families are without good shelters."

Takeaways

- **Kerala says it has totally eradicated extreme poverty**
- **Opposition, activists cast doubt on Left govt claim**
- **266-day ASHA workers' strike sullies Pinarayi image**

Others are celebrating. "It's a moment of pride," feted novelist Benyamin tells INDIA TODAY. "The few sceptical social scientists are out to please the Opposition or ignorant regarding the process." The CM, too, says the Opposition is being churlish at a historic moment. Perchance granting him solace, China's ambassador to India Xu Feihong took to X to congratulate Kerala. But all this is only one part of a rancorous debate. Destitution itself is a threshold phenomenon; Kerala is not wanting in other forms of want.

ANGELS IN DISTRESS

Take an epic 266-day protest by ASHA workers, a piece of grim political theatre that saw the regime adopt stances by turn cold, hostile and, finally, as its strategic blunder dawned on it, grudgingly capitulating. The grassroots workforce was seeking, inter alia, a trebling of their Rs 7,000 honorarium. The state stalled through many rounds of negotiations, making no attempt at resolution. On November 1, Pinarayi blinked, bundling a modest Rs 1,000 hike within a mega poll sop package of Rs 10,000 crore for poor women.

The strikers went back cheering, vowing to carry on protests in the districts. But Vadakara MLA K.K. Rema, wife of the slain Marxist mutineer T.P. Chandrasekharan who now heads the CPI(M) offshoot he founded, called it a "permanent black mark" on Kerala's visage of consummate welfarism. Why did the Left regime risk a stance that ran counter to every strand of its vaunted pro-social development model?

Partly fiscal reasons. But also, the strikers were affiliated to the far-left Socialist Unity Centre of India (SUCI). "Meeting their demands could hurt the CPI(M)-affiliated trade union CITU. But the big unions in Kerala are all in sleep mode. Only the far left is even looking at, say, the unorganised sector," says Rema. The Left, Congress and RSS-backed unions had all stayed away from the protest, while the Congress as a party was not above backing the protesters to taunt Pinarayi.

Pinarayi had called Kerala's 26,125 ASHA workers "angels of hope" during the COVID-19 crisis. "Now, we were being ridiculed by pro-regime cyber warriors. But we're not slaves and won't be deterred from our path," says S. Mini, key mover behind the strike. Kerala has never suffered from a poverty of irony. ■